

Plaintiff A person, organization, *state*, or country accusing a *defendant* in a *court* of law.

Precedent A principle or rule established by a *judgment* or ruling in a previous legal case. A precedent may be cited to justify a ruling in a subsequent case that deals with similar issues.

Prosecution The process of presenting *evidence* in an attempt to prove that a *defendant* is guilty of a crime.

Ratification The process of signing or formally approving a law, *treaty*, *contract*, *amendment*, or other agreement, making it legally valid.

Referendum A direct vote by the electorate on a specific issue, proposal, or policy.

Republic A *state* with no monarch, in which power resides with the people and is exercised by their elected representatives.

Revolution The sudden and often violent overthrow of a social order or political regime by the people.

Rights What a person is entitled to either by law or as a matter of ethics.

Roman law The legal system of the ancient Romans, which still forms the basis of many modern-day systems of *civil law*.

Sentence The punishment given by a *judge* to a *defendant* found guilty of a crime in a *court* of law.

Separation of powers The division of government into three branches—the *executive*, *judiciary*,

and *legislature*—that are separate, independent bodies, which ensures that no single branch gains too much power.

Sharia law The body of divine law in Islam that governs the religious and secular life of Muslims.

Sovereignty The authority held by a *state*—or by its ruler, leader, *parliament*, or government—that is not subject to any outside control or influences.

State 1) A *sovereign* political region and the people who live in it. 2) A member of a *federal* system. 3) A government and its institutions.

Statute A law that has been enacted by a *legislature* and formally written down. *Amendments* can be made to existing statutes.

Suffrage The right to vote in an *election* or *referendum*. Universal suffrage refers to the right to vote of *citizens* regardless of their gender, race, social status, or wealth. Women's suffrage describes the right of women to vote on the same basis as men.

Supreme court The highest judicial *court* in a country or *state*, which has *jurisdiction* over the lower courts. In the US, the Supreme Court is the highest *federal* court and has the power to interpret the US Constitution.

Tort law The branch of *civil law* that deals with wrongful actions of one party that cause another party to suffer loss or harm.

Trade union An organized group of employees who negotiate with employers and the government

to maintain and improve pay and working conditions.

Trademark A word, phrase, sign, or symbol that distinguishes the goods or services of one enterprise from those of other enterprises. A trademark can be registered, which gives the owner an exclusive right to use the trademark.

Treaty A formal *contract* that sets out agreements—such as a trade agreement, an alliance, or the end of hostilities—between *states*.

Trial A formal examination of *evidence* by a *judge* in a law *court* in order to reach a *verdict* in a *criminal* or *civil law* case.

Universal jurisdiction In *international law*, the power of a national *court* to prosecute individuals for serious crimes such as *crimes against humanity*, *war crimes*, and *genocide*, regardless of where the crime was committed.

Verdict The conclusion of a *judge* or *jury* based on the *evidence* that is presented in *court*.

War crime An act carried out in the conduct of war that violates the international laws and customs of war. Examples of war crimes include taking hostages, using child soldiers, and deliberately killing civilians or prisoners.

Warrant A legal document that allows someone to do something, particularly one that gives the police permission to make an arrest, seize goods, or search property.

Writ A formal legal document that orders a person to carry out, or stop carrying out, a specific action.